

Lab: Dual-Channel Communication

Group Activity — Communication

Objective

Experience and analyze the dual-channel communication of your crochet circle by experimenting with different combinations of physical and social channels, and by sharing stories that carry craft knowledge.

Materials

- Yarn and hooks for all participants
- A simple stitch pattern that everyone can follow
- Index cards and pens
- A timer
- Optional: a recording device for the storytelling round

Duration

50-60 minutes

Activity Steps

Step 1: Channel Separation Experiment (15 minutes)

Try three different communication modes for 5 minutes each. In each mode, one person teaches a simple technique (e.g., a puff stitch or a picot edge):

Mode A — Gestures Only (no words) The teacher demonstrates the technique using only their hands. No speaking, no mouthing words, no written instructions. The learner watches and tries to replicate.

Mode B — Words Only (no visual) The learner turns away or closes their eyes. The teacher explains the technique using only verbal instructions — no demonstration visible to the learner.

Mode C — Both Channels (normal) The teacher demonstrates and explains simultaneously, as they normally would.

After all three modes, discuss: - Which mode produced the most prediction error for the learner? - Which mode was most effective? Why? - What information travels well through the physical channel? What travels well through the social channel? - How much richer is the dual-channel experience compared to either channel alone?

Step 2: Story Circle (15 minutes)

Each person tells a **craft story** — a narrative from their crochet life that carries technical knowledge embedded in personal experience. The story should teach something, but through narrative rather than instruction. Examples: - A project that went wrong and what you learned - A technique you discovered by accident - A yarn that surprised you (for better or worse) - A crochet gift that meant something to the recipient

As each person tells their story, the rest of the group stitches and listens. After all stories: - What technical knowledge was embedded in the stories? - Were the stories more memorable than a list of tips would have been? - Did any story change how you think about your own crochet practice?

Step 3: Pattern Annotation (10 minutes)

Choose a written pattern that at least one group member has made. Pass copies around. The experienced member **annotates** the pattern verbally — adding warnings, tips, and predictions about where others will encounter difficulty.

Notice: - How much information does the verbal annotation add beyond what is written? - What kind of knowledge is missing from the written pattern that the annotator supplies? - How does this compare to downloading a pattern from the internet with no human context?

Step 4: Silent Giving (5 minutes)

Without speaking, each person does one small communicative act for someone else in the circle: - Move a skein closer to someone who is running low - Hold up someone's work admiringly (nonverbal compliment) - Offer a stitch marker or tool they might need - Simply make eye contact and smile

After the silent round, discuss: - What did you "say" without words? - What did others "say" to you? - How did the silent communication feel compared to verbal exchange?

Step 5: Reflection (5-10 minutes)

Discuss together: 1. How does the dual-channel nature of crochet circle communication create a unique social space? 2. What kinds of knowledge travel best through stories versus through patterns versus through demonstration? 3. How does your circle's communication extend beyond the meeting (group chat, social media, phone calls)? 4. What would be lost if your circle communicated only online?

Reflection Prompts

- Which communication experiment was most revealing?
- Did you discover something about how your circle communicates that you had not noticed before?
- How might you be more intentional about using stories to share craft knowledge?

Extension

Start a "Story Stitch" tradition: each meeting begins with one member's craft story. Over time, compile these into a shared collection (written or recorded). This becomes a communication artifact that carries the circle's collective generative model in narrative form.